

cover story WEST BENGAL

"we" was not lost on anybody. Headlines the next day attacked the "people's" chief minister for defending the brutalities of the motorcycle gangs of CPI(M) usurpers in Nandigram.

Right from the day he assumed a serious role in West Bengal politics, Buddhadeb has been known as a well-meaning though slightly arrogant communist who dared to cross swords with his mentor, the patriarch Jyoti Basu whom he succeeded as chief minister in 2000 and with whom he has been, sometimes unfavourably, compared constantly for the last seven years. Sadly, by the time Buddhadeb was six years into his chief ministership, Basu had this to say of his onetime favourite, "*Buddha to amar kachey asheyi na* (Buddha doesn't even visit me)." And even as Nandigram burnt in the recapture operation by CPI(M) goons, Buddhadeb was busy looking after the launch preparations of the Film Festival, his pet project.

But the isolation of Buddhadeb was already in place by then. State Governor Gopal Krishna Gandhi has taken on the government saying, "The



CALLING OUT THE army, the first time since 1992, showed the total failure of the state Government and is yet another blow to Buddhadeb's credibility



DUBIOUS ROLE: The violence led by people like Idris Ali shows that the minorities are losing faith in the Left and are vulnerable to exploitation

manner in which the recapture of Nandigram is being attempted is totally unlawful and unacceptable... against all norms of civilised political behaviour." Buddhadeb was being seen as the chief minister who fiddled while Nandigram burnt. His crude and misguided defense of the party's goon squads moved him a giant step away from the masses. Trinamool Congress chief Mamata Banerjee, known for her acerbic tongue, even remarked, "Atrocities on women are commonplace in Nandigram, thanks to CPI(M) cadres and the police. I wish I could disrobe Buddhadeb by yanking off his dhoti." Though her own credibility is questionable, it speaks volumes for the loss of respect for the chief minister. In Basu's time, Mamata would not have dared make such a statement.

To make matters worse for Buddhadeb, chairman of the National Human Rights Commission, S. Rajendra Babu, blasted the Left Front Government saying that it was